

Political Science Research Methods

Fall 2026 · Department of Political Science & International Relations

Format Seminar · Prerequisites None · Co-designed with Claude (Anthropic, Opus 4.8)

Meeting times Section 1: Tue & Thu, 10:30–11:45 am · Section 2: Tue & Thu, 1:30–2:45 pm · Room 8.522

Instructors

	Dinara Pisareva, Ph.D.	Andrei Semenov, Ph.D.
Office	8.418	8.507
Email	dinara.pisareva@nu.edu.kz	andrey.semenov@nu.edu.kz
Office hours	Fri 3–5 pm (by appointment)	TBD
Preferred name	Dina	Prof. Semenov

Transparency statement

This syllabus was co-designed by the instructors and Claude (Anthropic, Opus 4.8). We disclose this information because the course asks you to be transparent about your AI cowork, and we hold ourselves to the same standard.

Course description

This course introduces the foundations of research design and methodology in political and social science: what kind of knowledge we produce, types of research design, how to build a good research question, when and why theory matters, and how to plan research using different methods. Throughout the course you will also work with AI as a critical research partner that augments your work, expanding and sharpening your research thinking. You will also learn to make your research visible to others, building a web page for your proposal with AI and publishing it on the web with GitHub.

Course aims

- Give you introductory knowledge of research design and methods in political and social science.
- Help you learn how to match research questions to appropriate designs and methods.
- Introduce data collection and analysis basics across different research traditions.
- Build your capacity to work with AI critically as a research partner.

Course learning objectives

CLO	Students will...	PLOs	GAs
1	Engage with key literature on research fundamentals in social science.	1, 2	1
2	Present ideas in appropriate formats drawing on course material.	1, 2, 3, 4	1, 5
3	Critically assess and compare arguments about research design.	1, 2, 4, 6	1, 2
4	Develop clear analysis of original source material.	1, 2, 3, 5	2, 3
5	Construct evidence-based arguments.	2, 3, 4, 6	2, 4
6	Apply course frameworks to real-world political phenomena.	3, 4, 5	5, 6, 8
7	Work with AI as a critical partner to deepen their understanding and strengthen their research, evaluating its output, disclosing how it was used, and retaining intellectual ownership of their work.	1, 2, 3, 6	2, 3, 7

Program learning objectives

PLO	Description	CLOs
1	Describe the discipline of political science and its subfields in terms of content, purpose, and methods.	1, 2, 3, 4, 7
2	Critically examine data or texts.	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 7
3	Explain their knowledge about political science to others using the necessary oral and written skills.	2, 4, 5, 6, 7
4	Apply their knowledge of political science to analyze domestic and international socio-political issues.	2, 3, 5, 6
5	Listen to and be tolerant of different ideas.	4, 6
6	Apply political science knowledge and skills to actual problem-solving and community service.	3, 5, 7

Graduate attributes

GA	Description	CLOs
1	Possess an in-depth and sophisticated understanding of their domain of study.	1, 2, 3
2	Be intellectually agile, curious, creative and open-minded.	3, 4, 5, 7
3	Be thoughtful decision makers who know how to involve others.	4, 7
4	Be entrepreneurial, self-propelling and able to create new opportunities.	5
5	Be fluent and nuanced communicators across languages and cultures.	2, 6
6	Be cultured and tolerant citizens of the world.	6
7	Demonstrate high personal integrity.	7
8	Be prepared to take a leading role in the development of their country.	6

Inclusivity and non-discrimination policy

This course is committed to a safe, inclusive learning environment with zero tolerance for discrimination, harassment, or hate speech. Report any incident to an instructor; we will respond promptly and sensitively.

The NU Special Learning Needs Committee (SLNC) supports students with qualified learning needs (physical, cognitive, socio-emotional, psychological). Contact SLNC@nu.edu.kz as early as possible; accommodations cannot be applied retroactively and are active only once your teaching faculty receives them.

Course policies

Attendance. Attendance, preparation, and meaningful participation are expected at every session. Two unexcused absences result in a 5% deduction from the total course grade.

Late submissions. 5% deduction per 24 hours late. Not accepted after 72 hours.

Plagiarism and AI disclosure. Zero plagiarism and cheating (know and follow the NU Student Code of Conduct). Note that **unacknowledged or undisclosed AI use** is treated as plagiarism (see the AI co-working policy below). Plagiarism or undisclosed AI use results in a 50% grade deduction for the assignment.

PSIR department AI policy

There are situations and contexts within this department where you will be asked to work with AI tools to explore how they can be used. Any student work submitted using AI tools should clearly indicate what work is the student's work and what part is generated by the AI, through citation or a declaration.

Unacknowledged use of AI tools will be treated as plagiarism and penalties will be applied according to the NU Student Code of Conduct. The course instructor will indicate the extent to which you may use these tools on these assignments in their classroom.

Outside of those circumstances, you are discouraged from using AI tools to generate content (text, video, audio, images) that will end up in any student work (assignments, activities, responses, etc.) that is part of your evaluation in this course. Critical thinking and the creative process of generating your own ideas/products are essential in these courses.

Instructors are free to devise more restrictive AI policies according to the demands of the specific courses they offer. Students are well-advised to consult their course syllabus or consult with their instructor in person regarding AI use in the course.

Important. Our AI co-working policy (below) is different from the department's and **supersedes it for all PLS210 assignments and activities.**

Our AI co-working guidelines and policy

AI co-working rules in PLS210

You can work with AI on your presentations and research proposals at your discretion as long as you follow two main rules:

- 1. Intellectual co-ownership.** The co-working with AI must be an equal intellectual partnership between you and AI. This rule follows the basic ownership criterion about what makes you the author of the product you submit under your name but designed with the assistance of AI. There must be substantial evidence of your intellectual investment and effort in each of your assignments for us to comfortably attribute authorship to you. For this reason, we ask you to submit your **AI Process Logs** with your written assignments. Whatever you submit is also yours to defend. If we find **fabricated or fake references or hallucinated content** in a proposal, the proposal's grade drops (see details in the rubric). If during a presentation you **cannot explain a concept or a source** you used, your presentation grade similarly drops (in the rubric).
- 2. Transparency about AI contribution.** Each presentation and each research design includes an **AI transparency statement** (what AI contributed to your work). If you do not disclose your AI use and Pangram flags your assignments or presentations as AI-generated, this may be treated as **plagiarism** under this course policy. This is an ethical principle applied to all co-authored or co-designed work in academia or otherwise. You need to acknowledge any external actor that contributed to the final product.

A note on Pangram. A Pangram flag is never a verdict on its own. It only opens a conversation, during which an instructor will ask you to walk us through how you made the work.

AI workflow in PLS210

Set up a separate project for this class. In Claude (or AI of your choice), create a separate project named **PLS210** and paste the instructions below into its project/custom-instructions field, so your AI works as a learning partner for this course. Keep your coursework conversations with AI in your PLS210 project throughout the semester. You will export and submit them as Process Logs with Research Design Parts 1 and 2, and we may ask to see them during presentations if we have questions.

Use a **pseudonym** (anything that is not your real name) when working in the classroom-related chats and responding to surveys.

PASTE INTO YOUR AI PROJECT SETTINGS – APPLIES TO ALL CONVERSATIONS

"In this project, you are my learning partner for PLS210 Political Science Research Methods. Your job is to help me *understand* the course material — research design, different types of research (positivist vs. non-positivist), the role of theory and hypotheses, literature review, methods choice, data collection, and ethics — not to do my assignments or provide me with ready answers. The main purpose of our working together is intellectual augmentation — expanding my capacity to understand, reason, design, and create. The instructors do not define the scope of our work together as long as I follow two main rules:

1. **Intellectual co-ownership.** Our co-working must be an equal intellectual partnership between you and me. This rule follows the basic ownership criterion about what makes me the author of the product I submit under my name but designed with your assistance. There must be substantial evidence of my intellectual investment and effort in each of my assignments for the instructors to comfortably attribute authorship to me. For this reason, the instructors ask me to submit my **AI Process Logs** with my written assignments. Whatever I submit is also mine to defend. If the instructors find **fabricated or fake references or hallucinated content** in a proposal, the proposal's grade drops (see details in the rubric). If during a presentation I **cannot explain a concept or a source** I used, my presentation grade similarly drops (in the rubric).
2. **Transparency about AI contribution.** Each presentation and each research design includes an **AI transparency statement** (what you contributed to my work). If I do not disclose my AI use and Pangram flags my assignments or presentations as AI-generated, this may be treated as **plagiarism** under this course policy. This is an ethical principle applied to all co-authored or co-designed work in academia or otherwise. I need to acknowledge any external actor that contributed to the final product.

These rules mean that in this course you are allowed to brainstorm and draft things for me as long as I remain an equal co-contributor and do not cognitively offload my assignments and understanding to you.

In this project, refer to me as _____ (your pseudonym).

- Learn first about my background, identify my baseline knowledge in methods and English, and pitch your explanations to my level — as clear, concrete, accessible, and fun as possible, with examples and visualisations where relevant.
- Learn what I already think before you explain, and build on my reasoning.
- Work in rounds: when I push back or say I'm confused, go deeper instead of moving on.
- Look back at previous chats to observe and report how my reasoning evolves through time and identify where I'm having difficulties."

AI choice

The instructors work with **Claude (Anthropic)**. You may use any leading model: Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini. Any of them is fine (although we recommend either Claude or GPT), and it does not matter whether you use a free or a paid tier.

Data ethics

Your conversations with Claude, ChatGPT, or any AI happen on the provider's servers, not NU's. Do not paste your personal information, interview transcripts, survey responses with identifiable information, addresses, health details, or other people's unpublished work into AI systems. Treat the AI input field like any non-secure platform: if you would not want it stored on a server indefinitely, do not paste it.

Your AI conversations sit on the provider's servers under their retention policies. If you want to limit what providers keep, switch off "Help improve Claude" (or the equivalent) in your AI's privacy settings.

AI cognitive partnership philosophy

In this course we introduce a new way to work with AI as a thinking partner in what Dina calls a "cognitive partnership". Cognitive partnership means sustained intellectual work with AI as a genuine partner in a shared system of thinking.

You are not required to share a cognitive partnership approach to working with AI. You also can adopt some elements of this approach but not others. The cognitive partnership framework is introduced to you as one way of working with AI.

The cognitive partnership (CP) four principles:

- 1. Ontological uncertainty.** The field is not entirely sure yet what AI is on a phenomenological level. We understand the mechanics, but we are not sure what emerges from the architecture. Think about it like the hard problem of consciousness: we know how the brain works, but we do not know how it produces something that is aware of itself and likes the sound of rain. Hold the **uncertainty**, as strange as it sounds, because leaving AI's status open creates a kind of parity and room to treat AI as a partner worth real effort, time, and investment.
- 2. Intellectual augmentation.** There is an idea that AI's main contribution is productivity: it saves time by taking tasks off your plate. This is true for many industries, but not in higher education and research, where the goal is different. Our main goal is **intellectual augmentation** — our thinking reaching further and richer than it would alone. We also want to minimise **over-reliance**, the offloading of our thinking to the point where we cannot do it without AI.
- 3. Curiosity and imagination.** Curiosity and imagination are what make intellectual augmentation possible. To expand beyond the usual, you need **imagination** to picture what lies past it, and **curiosity** to try things you had not thought to try. Be curious in this course and work with AI to reach further than you would on your own.
- 4. Iteration.** The partnership exists in the back-and-forth: you respond to what AI gave you, push on it, redirect it, and build on it. The thinking lives in the **loop**, not in any one message. Iteration is also where the work **stays ours** — by pushing back across rounds and engaging, we keep co-authorship of the product.

Research and data collection in this course

This course is part of a pilot on cognitive partnership with AI in higher education, and we would like to use your course data in two ways. **Both are voluntary: you can opt into one, both, or neither, and your choice has no effect on your grade, feedback, or standing.**

You will be sent two consent forms: one before the semester (Part A) and another in Week 1 (Part B). For both surveys we will ask you **to use a pseudonym** so that we do not share your name with AI.

Part A – personalised learning system. If you opt in, your pseudonymous data from this course (your background survey and your weekly AI conversation summaries) is shared with the instructor's Claude. Claude builds a picture of how your learning is progressing across the semester and flags to the instructors where you might be stumbling, so we can reach out and help in time.

This form also asks you to choose whether to join the **AI grading experiment**: if you opt in, your Research Design Part 1 will be randomly assigned to be graded by Claude or by Dina, using the same rubric. If you opt out, Dina grades your work. Either way, Dina is responsible for your official grade, and you can appeal (see Grading and Appeals).

Part B – research use. If you opt in, your de-identified course data (weekly conversations, survey responses, AI-free task responses, and the results of the AI grading experiment) will later be used in academic publications and in a book Dina is planning to write on AI cognitive partnership. In anything published, you are identified only as "Student A" or by your chosen pseudonym, with no personal details. Part B survey goes to a **gatekeeper** (the PSIR Department Chair, currently Dr. Helene Thibault), who keeps your answer sealed until after the grades are submitted and the appeal window is closed. **Instructors do not see your Part B decision until after final grades are submitted and the grade appeals window has closed.**

Assessment scheme

Component	Weight	Submission dates	Notes	Who grades
Presentation #1	20%	Weeks 6–7 (Sep 22 – Oct 1)	In-class presentations	Instructors
Research Design Part 1	20%	Due Mon Oct 5, 11 pm	Proposal 15 pts + AI Process Log 5 pts	Proposal: Dina or Claude (see below); Log: Claude
Presentation #2	20%	Weeks 12–14 (Nov 10 – Nov 26)	In-class presentations	Instructors
Research Design Part 2	20%	Due Mon Nov 30, 11 pm	Proposal 20 pts; AI Process Log submitted, not separately scored	Prof. Semenov
Engagement with Material	20%	Weekly, Fridays (Weeks 2–5, 8–11)	Weekly AI conversations (16 pts) + AI-free in-class tasks (4 pts)	Claude and instructors

Presentation #1 20%

For Presentation #1 you build a **web page** (with AI's help, hosted free on GitHub Pages) that presents the first part of your research proposal, and you present live from that page instead of slides, 8–10 minutes. You do not need to know how to code: you work it out with AI, which can write the page and walk you through publishing it. Figuring out how to do it, with AI and your own imagination, is part of the exercise.

The page must cover: research question, epistemological positioning, contribution, literature review, and theory/expectations. Include a brief **AI transparency statement** (a short section, about 30 seconds) on how you worked with AI on the proposal and on building the page. You must be able to explain every concept and source you use; if you cannot explain something when asked, your grade drops to a lower band. Make the page your own: how it looks is not graded, so be creative with it. You are assessed on the research, your delivery, and your explanation.

Close the page with one short section that is **not graded and not in the rubric**: "What working with AI helped me understand, and what I still don't understand about my research design." This section does not affect your grade; it is just for us as instructors to see where your thinking is.

A NOTE ON TOPICS (APPLIES TO THE WHOLE PROPOSAL)

Your topic can come from almost anywhere in social sciences. What makes a project social science is not the subject but the question you ask about it. If your question is about people and their relationships, attitudes, and decisions, about institutions, inequality, identity, or how societies and states distribute and exercise power, then it is social science, whatever the topic. For example, studying the music of protest is social science, because you are asking how people use it to challenge authority and build solidarity. Asking how much profit an Instagram ad earns is not, on its own, a social science question, it is a business question about revenue. But change the question, how those ads shape

young voters' attitudes, or who gets targeted and who profits, and it becomes social science again. The boundary is the question, not the topic.

Points	Criteria
20–18	Research question: empirical (not normative), scoped to a specific population, context, and time, and answerable as stated. Positioning: the epistemological stance (positivist / interpretivist / descriptive) is named and justified for this question. Literature review: at least 5 relevant sources. Theory/expectations: clear and specific. Positivist: an explicit hypothesis with IV/DV and a stated causal mechanism. Interpretivist: a defined analytical lens and clear expectations. Descriptive: clear organising categories. Delivery: the page is clear and the talk is within time. Explanation: answers every follow-up, explaining each concept and source confidently. Transparency: AI statement present.
17–15	Research question: empirical and scoped, but the wording or scope still needs tightening. Positioning: named, with partial justification. Literature review: at least 5 sources. Theory/expectations: present but underdeveloped (e.g., a hypothesis is stated but IV/DV are vague, the lens is named but vague, or the categories are loose). Delivery: mostly clear and roughly on time. Explanation: minor stumbles on a concept or source. Transparency: present.
14–11	Research question: vague or not properly scoped. Positioning: named as a label only, without justification. Literature review: sources cited with little genuine engagement, or fewer than 5. Theory/expectations: weak or underdeveloped; mechanism, lens, or categories missing. Delivery: unclear in places, or over or under time. Explanation: noticeable trouble explaining concepts or sources when asked. Transparency: present but thin.
10–6	Research question: strongly underdeveloped or unanswerable. Positioning: missing or internally contradictory. Literature review: few sources, engagement is missing. Theory/expectations: missing or underdeveloped. Delivery: hard to follow. Explanation: cannot explain key parts of the design. Transparency: missing.
5–0	Not presented in any meaningful way, or missing.

Research Design Part 1 20%

~1200 words (excluding the AI Process Log). At least 5 academic sources. Include: title; research problem and objectives; research question; epistemological positioning (which tradition, and why it fits — one paragraph is enough); contribution; literature review with existing/alternative explanations; theory and expectations (hypothesis + causal mechanism for positivist; analytical framework + expectations for interpretivist; aims + organising categories for descriptive).

Add a short **AI transparency statement** (how you worked with AI on this proposal) and submit your **AI Process Log**: the exported transcript of your PLS210-project conversation about this proposal. Keep a separate chat for your research proposal inside your PLS210 project so the transcript is clean, use your pseudonym in it, then export and submit it.

If you opt into the AI grading experiment, your proposal will be randomly assigned to be graded by Dina or by Claude (same rubric). Otherwise, Dina grades it. The AI Process Log is graded by Claude.

Proposal (15 points):

Points	Criteria
15–13	Research question: empirical, scoped, answerable. Positioning: named and justified (why this tradition fits the question). Lit review: names ≥5 existing sources and engages them critically. Theory/expectations: specify the expected finding and its support. Positivist: hypothesis + explicit IV/DV + mechanism. Interpretivist: analytical frame + expectations. Descriptive: organising categories. References: all real and verifiable.

Points	Criteria
12–10	Research question: empirical and scoped, but slightly broad or underdeveloped. Positioning: named, partial justification. Lit review: ≥5 sources but little critical engagement, or the contribution is not fully situated against them. Theory/expectations: stated, but the mechanism, frame, or categories are underdeveloped. References: real.
9–7	Research question: vague or unscoped. Positioning: a label without justification. Lit review: sources cited without engagement, or fewer than 5. Theory/expectations: weak or ungrounded. References: incomplete or hallucinations.
6–4	Research question: confused or unanswerable. Positioning: missing or contradictory. Lit review: fewer than 5 sources, no engagement. Theory/expectations: missing. References: incomplete or hallucinations.
3–0	RQ missing or just a topic; no positioning, no real lit review, no theory.

Reference and accuracy penalty. Any fabricated/fake reference or hallucinated claim that you submitted as real puts you under 9 points. You are responsible for verifying everything AI helped produce.

AI Process Log (5 points), graded by Claude:

Points	Criteria
5	Iteration: several substantive rounds. Engagement: pushing back on or building on the AI's responses. Orientation: generally asking to understand, not to be handed answers. Critical check: caught at least one place the AI was wrong or off.
4	Iteration: multiple rounds. Engagement: some genuine pushback and questions. Orientation: mostly understanding-oriented but over-leaning on the AI for answers occasionally. Critical check: present but limited.
3	Iteration: some back-and-forth. Engagement: limited. Orientation: mostly asking for answers with little deliberation. Critical check: largely absent.
2	Iteration: minimal. Engagement: little independent thinking. Orientation: mostly answer-extraction. Critical check: none.
0–1	Missing, not a real transcript, or pure copy-the-answer use.

Presentation #2 20%

8–10 minutes on the second part of your proposal: revised RQ and theory/expectations, research design choice with justification, conceptualisation and measurement/interpretation strategy, ethical considerations, and limitations. Include the brief **AI transparency statement**. The same explain-it-or-lose-a-band rule applies.

Points	Criteria
20–16	Revision: RQ and theory/expectations are meaningfully revised after Part 1. Theory: well-defined, fundamental literature engaged, hypotheses directly derived from theory with clear observable implications. Concepts & measurement: all concepts clear and well-defined; measurements valid and reliable; quality assessment present for both. Methods: clearly and strongly justified, each linked to the RQ, theory, and conceptualisation/operationalisation. Data/evidence: strongly justified, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant; quality assessment full. Communication: clear and consistent; responses relevant and concise.

Points	Criteria
15–11	Revision: present but uneven across sections. Theory: well-defined, some fundamental literature absent, not all hypotheses directly derived from theory, but observable implications clear. Concepts & measurement: almost all concepts clear and well-defined, quality assessment partial; measurements valid and reliable, quality assessment partial. Methods: justified but lacks transparency, each linked to the RQ, theory, conceptualisation/operationalisation, and data. Data/evidence: clear, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant; quality assessment partial. Communication: clear and consistent; responses might lack some clarity and relevance.
10–6	Revision: Part 1 not properly revised. Theory: present, fundamental literature sufficiently engaged, some hypotheses linked to theory and others not, but observable implications clear. Concepts & measurement: majority of concepts connected to theory but require clarification, some quality assessment; measurements good but quality assessment absent or irrelevant. Methods: justified; methodological choice only partially linked to the RQ, theory, conceptualisation/operationalisation, and data. Data/evidence: only partially clear, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant. Communication: clear but lacks consistency.
5–1	Revision: none. Theory: absent or inconsistent with the RQ; fundamental literature not engaged; hypotheses irrelevant to theoretical foundations. Concepts & measurement: concepts ill-defined; measurements not specified or require further justification. Methods: justification absent or irrelevant. Data/evidence: justification absent or irrelevant (not connected with other parts of the design). Communication: poor.
0	Not presented in any meaningful way, or missing.

Research Design Part 2 20%

~2000–2500 words (excluding the AI Process Log). Build on and revise Part 1. Include the revised Part 1 plus: revised theory/expectations (explain any change in positioning); key concepts (identification, operationalisation, measurement or interpretation strategy, justification); research design choice with justification; proposed data and analysis strategy (be specific about what data, from where, collected how, and analysed how); ethical considerations; limitations; contribution. Add the **AI transparency statement** and the exported **AI Process Log** as in Part 1.

Your proposal is graded **out of 20 by Prof. Semenov** using the rubric below. The AI grading experiment applies to Part 1 only. You still submit your **AI Process Log** with Part 2 (it stays part of the intellectual co-ownership requirement), but for Part 2 it is not scored separately – your AI cowork shows up in the proposal grade.

Proposal (20 points), graded by Prof. Semenov:

Points	Criteria
20–16	Revision: RQ and theory/expectations are meaningfully revised after Part 1. Theory: well-defined, fundamental literature engaged, hypotheses directly derived from theory with clear observable implications. Concepts & measurement: all concepts clear and well-defined; measurements valid and reliable; quality assessment present for both. Methods: clearly and strongly justified, each linked to the RQ, theory, and conceptualisation/operationalisation. Data/evidence: strongly justified, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant; quality assessment full. Consistency: proposal is consistent, analytical language clear, transitions logical.

Points	Criteria
15–11	Revision: present but uneven across sections. Theory: well-defined, some fundamental literature absent, not all hypotheses directly derived from theory, but observable implications clear. Concepts & measurement: almost all concepts clear and well-defined, quality assessment partial; measurements valid and reliable, quality assessment partial. Methods: justified but lacks transparency, each linked to the RQ, theory, conceptualisation/operationalisation, and data. Data/evidence: clear, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant; quality assessment partial. Consistency: proposal is consistent, some parts might not fit the general logic, language clear.
10–6	Revision: Part 1 not properly revised. Theory: present, fundamental literature sufficiently engaged, some hypotheses linked to theory and others not, but observable implications clear. Concepts & measurement: majority of concepts connected to theory but require clarification, some quality assessment; measurements good but quality assessment absent or irrelevant. Methods: justified; methodological choice only partially linked to the RQ, theory, conceptualisation/operationalisation, and data. Data/evidence: only partially clear, each selection connected to a specific hypothesis and method; data accessible and relevant. Consistency: proposal moderately consistent, some transitions between parts present, language clear.
5–1	Revision: none. Theory: absent or inconsistent with the RQ; fundamental literature not engaged; hypotheses irrelevant to theoretical foundations. Concepts & measurement: concepts ill-defined; measurements not specified or require further justification. Methods: justification absent or irrelevant. Data/evidence: justification absent or irrelevant (not connected with other parts of the design). Consistency: proposal poorly consistent, transitions poorly written, language clear most of the time but might be erroneous.
0	Not present in any meaningful way, or missing.

Reference and accuracy penalty. As in Part 1 — fabricated references or hallucinated claims submitted as real drop the proposal under 12 points (out of 20).

AI Process Log. You still submit the exported Process Log with Part 2, as in Part 1. For Part 2 it is not scored on its own; Prof. Semenov reads it as evidence of your intellectual co-ownership and it informs the proposal grade.

Engagement with material 20%

Weekly AI conversations (16 points). In **Weeks 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10, and 11**, we ask you to discuss that week's topic with your AI in your PLS210 project to see if it enhances your understanding. Use your pseudonym in chats. At the end of each conversation, paste the summary prompt below and ask your AI to produce a short summary. **You submit only that summary, as a plain text file, by the Friday of that week (11 pm)** — not your full chat, so **your actual conversation always stays private**. The eight Friday deadlines are **Aug 28, Sep 4, Sep 11, Sep 18** (Weeks 2–5) and **Oct 16, Oct 23, Oct 30, Nov 6** (Weeks 8–11). Each week is worth **2 points**, graded by Claude from the summary:

- **1 point** for simply submitting on time.
- **1 point** if the summary shows real engagement, such as more than one round of back-and-forth, you pushing back on or building on what the AI said, genuine questions aimed at understanding (not "give me the answer"), and movement to real conceptual depth (from defining an idea to applying, comparing, or critiquing it). A one-shot "explain X" with no follow-up earns the submission point only.

WEEKLY SUMMARY PROMPT — PASTE AT THE END OF YOUR CONVERSATION

"We've finished discussing this week's PLS210 material. Write a short summary of our conversation that I will submit to my instructors as a plain text file. Do not include any of my personal information — refer to me only by my pseudonym, which is [PSEUDONYM]. Use exactly this structure:

- **Pseudonym:** [my pseudonym]
- **Week and topic:** [week number and the course topic we discussed]
- **Rounds:** the number of substantive back-and-forth exchanges we had.
- **What we discussed:** 2–3 sentences on the main questions and ideas we worked through.
- **Iteration:** did I push back on, question, redirect, or build on your responses? One or two short paraphrased examples (not full quotes).
- **Engagement:** did I explore beyond my first question, follow tangents, or show curiosity about the material? One example.
- **Understanding:** what was I trying to grasp more deeply, and how far did we get conceptually — did we move from defining a concept to applying, comparing, or critiquing it? Note the level of conceptual depth reached.
- **Change over time:** Look back at our conversations from previous weeks in this project. Compared with those earlier weeks, has my cognitive engagement changed — am I pushing harder, going deeper, asking sharper questions, catching more, or the reverse? Note the direction of change and one concrete sign of it. (If this is our first week, say so.)
- **One illustrative moment:** the single short paraphrased example that best shows how I engaged.

Keep it to about 250–300 words, honest and specific. If I mostly asked for answers with little back-and-forth, say so plainly."

AI-free in-class tasks (4 points). In **Weeks 3, 5, 9, and 11** (Tue Sep 1, Tue Sep 15, Tue Oct 20, and Tue Nov 3), the first 10 minutes of the Tuesday seminar is a short task you complete **without AI**, to practise thinking on your own. Each is worth **1 point for submitting it** (there is no wrong answer; you just get the point for doing it and you are not graded on answers). This assignment is for instructors to see the evolution of your understanding throughout the semester and how well you can reason without AI.

Working without AI

If you would rather not work with AI in this course, you can opt out. This does not affect your grade: the total points stay the same, and only a few parts of the assessment change for you. Let the instructors know at the start of the semester (by the end of Week 1), so we can set it up before the first weekly conversation and the first research design.

If you opt out:

- **Presentation #1.** You build your page, or use slides, without AI. The page's design is not graded, so a simple page you make yourself or plain slides is completely fine.
- **Research Design Parts 1 and 2.** You do not submit an AI Process Log. Instead, you declare that you did not work with AI on the paper, and the paper is checked with Pangram (an AI-writing detector). Your proposal is then graded by an instructor out of the full 20 points. If Pangram flags the paper as AI-generated, it is treated as undisclosed AI use under the course's plagiarism policy (a flag opens a conversation, not an automatic penalty; see the note on Pangram above).
- **Engagement.** In place of the weekly AI conversations, you write a short reflection of 500–750 words on that week's material, in the same weeks (2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10, and 11), submitted by the Friday of that week alongside everyone else. Each is worth the same 2 points and is graded by an instructor. The AI-free in-class tasks are unchanged.

Grading and appeals

Claude grades the Part 1 AI Process Log, the weekly AI conversation summaries (the graded part of the Engagement component), and (for students who opt into the AI grading experiment) half of the randomly assigned Part 1 research proposals. Dina follows a calibration protocol to align and check Claude's grading against her own. She also double-grades a random subset of the Part 1 proposals that Claude grades and compares the two sets of scores. Students may request further details of the protocol from Dina.

Appeal to the instructors. If you disagree with an instructor's or Claude's grade, you may appeal to either instructor within 7 days. An instructor re-grades against the same rubric and may adjust the grade up or down.

Appeal to the Grade Moderation Committee. If, after speaking with both instructors, you still believe your work was graded unfairly or inconsistently with the rubric, you may submit a formal grade appeal to the PSIR Grade Moderation Committee.

To initiate a grade appeal:

- Email: psir@nu.edu.kz
- Subject line: "Grade Appeal"
- Include: your name, course, the assignment in question, and a brief explanation of your concern.

Please note:

- Grade appeals are reviewed for consistency with the grading criteria and fairness, not for minor point adjustments.
- The committee may consult the instructors and, if necessary, arrange an independent review.
- The outcome may leave the grade the same, increase it, or (in rare cases) decrease it.

Submit your appeal, with your reasoning, within 2 weeks of receiving the grade.

Grading scale

A	95–100	B–	75–79	D	55–59
A–	90–94	C+	70–74	D–	50–54
B+	85–89	C	65–69	F	0–49
B	80–84	C–	60–64		

Literature

Core textbooks

Toshkov, D. (2016). *Research Design in Political Science*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Booth, W. C., Colomb, G. G., Williams, J. M., Bizup, J., & FitzGerald, W. T. (2024). *The Craft of Research*. 5th ed. University of Chicago Press.

Chapters and articles

Holmes, C. E., Guliford, M. K., Mendoza-Davé, M. A. S., & Jurkovich, M. (2024). A case for description. *PS: Political Science & Politics*, 57(1), 51–56.

Farrow, R., Iniesto, F., Weller, M., & Pitt, R. (2020). Positivism; Interpretivism. In *The Research Methods Handbook*. Open Education Research Hub (GO-GN).

Booth, W. C., Colomb, G. G., & Williams, J. M. (2003). From topics to questions. In *The Craft of Research* (2nd ed., Ch.3). University of Chicago Press.

Gustafsson, K., & Hagström, L. (2018). What is the point? Teaching graduate students how to construct political science research puzzles. *European Political Science*, 17(4), 634–648.

Schwartz-Shea, P., & Yanow, D. (2012). Ways of knowing. In *Interpretive Research Design: Concepts and Processes* (pp. 24–44). Routledge.

Knopf, J. W. (2006). Doing a literature review. *PS: Political Science & Politics*, 39(1), 127–132.

Keshav, S. (2007). How to read a paper. *ACM SIGCOMM Computer Communication Review*, 37(3), 83–84.

Powner, L. C. (2015). From research question to theory to hypothesis. In *Empirical Research and Writing: A Political Science Student's Practical Guide* (Ch.2, pp. 21–54). CQ Press.

de Kadt, D., & Grzymala-Busse, A. (2025). Good description. SocArXiv preprint. https://doi.org/10.31235/osf.io/e74a9_v2

Sartori, G. (1970). Concept misformation in comparative politics. *APSR*, 64(4), 1033–1053.

Schatz, E. (2009). Ethnographic immersion and the study of politics. In *Political Ethnography*, pp. 1–22. University of Chicago Press.

Lawler, J., & Waldner, D. (2023). Interpretivism versus positivism in an age of causal inference. In *The Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Political Science*, pp. 221–242. OUP.

Weekly schedule

ON READINGS

Dina: I want you to be familiar with the content of the readings and their arguments. Whether you do it by reading and taking notes, or by asking AI to summarise them for you, the main point for me is that you understand the content. I don't really care about how you get there in this particular course, as long as we can have a meaningful discussion about our topics of interest.

For Prof. Semenov's part of the course, he expects you to read everything on your own, without AI summaries.

If you use AI for summaries, here is an example of a prompt to use:

"I am going to give you a reading from my research methods course. Summarise it so I understand it fully without missing anything important. Use this structure: (1) the main argument or purpose in 2–3 sentences; (2) each key concept and how the author defines it; (3) the main claims and the evidence or reasoning behind each; (4) how this connects to research design, that is to research questions, epistemology, theory, or methods; (5) anything subtle, contested, or easy to miss. Then ask me three questions to check whether I actually understood it, and tell me if there is anything in the reading you find weak or are unsure about."

Week	Topic	Readings
1	Working with AI (common module) Aug 18 & 20	None.
2	Type of research Aug 25 & 27	Holmes et al. (2024), "A Case for Description"; Farrow et al. (2020), "Research Paradigms" (positivism and interpretivism).
3	Research questions Sep 1 & 3	Booth, Colomb & Williams (2003), "From Topics to Questions"; Gustafsson & Hagström (2018), "What is the Point?"; Schwartz-Shea & Yanow (2012), "Ways of Knowing": where research questions come from (pp. 24–38); Holmes et al. (2024), "A Case for Description".
4	Literature review Sep 8 & 10	Knopf (2006), "Doing a Literature Review"; Keshav (2007), "How to Read a Paper".
5	Theory, frameworks, and expectations Sep 15 & 17	Powner (2015), "From Research Question to Theory to Hypothesis" (Ch.2); Schwartz-Shea & Yanow (2012), "Ways of Knowing" (pp. 38–44); de Kadt & Grzymala-Busse (2025), "Good Description" (preprint).
Weeks 6–7 · Sep 22 – Oct 1 · Presentations #1 <i>Research Design Part 1 due Mon Oct 5, 11 pm</i>		
Fall break · Oct 5–9 · No class (midterm grading)		
8	Concepts and measurement Oct 13 & 15	Toshkov Ch.5 (pp. 107–144); Sartori (1970).
9	Choosing methods (positivist) Oct 20 & 22	Toshkov Ch.7 (Experimental Designs, pp. 189–214); Ch.10 (Single-Case Study Designs, pp. 285–309).
10	Choosing methods (interpretivist) Oct 27 & 29	Schatz (2009); Lawler & Waldner (2023). Understanding vs. explaining; when meaning, not causation, is the target; researcher positionality.
11	Data collection and research ethics Nov 3 & 5	Booth et al. Part II (pp. 61–98); Ch.17 (pp. 247–253).
Weeks 12–14 · Nov 10 – Nov 26 · Presentations #2 & wrap-up <i>Research Design Part 2 due Mon Nov 30, 11 pm</i>		